

A Region Still Being Drawn

Lesson 6 — The Middle East in 1945: mandates, oil, and the Arab League

What you will know and be able to do

1

Describe the mandate system's legacy across the Middle East by 1945

2

Explain the Arab League's founding purpose and its early limitations

3

Identify how oil was already reshaping great-power interest in the region

4

Begin using cause and consequence to explain why 1945 was not a clean starting point

A region shaped before our period even begins

1945 looks like a natural starting point, but nothing here starts from zero. The mandate system, oil discoveries, and unresolved promises made decades earlier all still actively shaped the region as the Second World War ended.

Independence for some, not for all

After the First World War, former Ottoman Arab territories became League of Nations mandates, intended as a temporary stage toward independence. By 1946, most had achieved it — Transjordan gained full independence that year. Palestine was the deliberate exception: Britain's mandate combined a promise of Arab self-government with a separate commitment to a Jewish national home, a contradiction never resolved during nearly three decades of British rule.

The 1936–39 Arab Revolt, and its long shadow

A six-month Arab general strike in 1936 escalated into a sustained revolt against British rule and Jewish immigration, provoking Britain's 1939 White Paper limiting Jewish immigration just as Nazi persecution in Europe was intensifying. The revolt's suppression also badly weakened Palestinian Arab political leadership — a weakness historians argue directly shaped how poorly prepared Palestinian Arabs were for the crisis of 1947–48.

The Arab League, founded March 1945

Egypt, Iraq, Transjordan, Lebanon, Saudi Arabia, and Syria founded the Arab League in Cairo on 22 March 1945, joined by Yemen in May; its founding pact explicitly affirmed Arab rights in Palestine. The League gave Arab states a shared diplomatic voice — but member states' own rivalries, particularly Transjordan's ambitions in Palestine worrying Egypt, Syria, and Saudi Arabia, limited how unified that voice actually was.

Oil, and why outside powers cared so much

By 1945, oil had already transformed how Britain, and increasingly the United States, viewed the Gulf and wider Middle East — not as a peripheral colonial concern but as a strategically vital resource base. This economic reality sits underneath nearly every foreign relations question this course will ask about the region.

Three unresolved tensions, all inherited

By 1945: an unresolved, deliberately unfinished mandate in Palestine; a new regional organisation whose unity was already more apparent than real; and outside powers increasingly interested in the region for reasons having little to do with its own peoples' aspirations. None of what follows in this course can be understood without these three inherited tensions.

A first argument-evaluation attempt

'The mandate system, more than any single decision made after 1945, explains the region's instability in the following decades.' To what extent do you agree?

- State your position clearly in an opening two sentences
- Use at least one specific fact about the mandate system's legacy
- Note one factor from after 1945 that might complicate this claim

Key terms from today

Mandate system

League of Nations arrangement intended to guide former Ottoman territories to independence.

White Paper of 1939

British policy sharply limiting Jewish immigration to Palestine.

Arab League

Regional organisation of Arab states, founded Cairo, March 1945.

Strategic resource

Oil's transformation of great-power interest in the region by the 1940s.

What to remember

By 1945, the Middle East already carried an unresolved mandate contradiction in Palestine, a newly founded but internally divided Arab League, and rapidly growing outside interest driven by oil. Nothing that follows in this topic starts from a clean slate.

Lesson 7 — The Partition of Palestine and the 1948 War

Next lesson: the UN Partition Plan, its rejection, and the war that redrew the map before the ink on the plan had even dried.